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The Ingenious Machine

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Chapter One: The Place Whose Name Was Removed

En algún lugar del Bajío, cuyo nombre ha sido removed from the available context, there stood a data center that had once promised to remember everything. The available context did permit us to say that it occupied a wooded property outside Amealco de Bonfil, in the highlands of Querétaro. The people who lived nearby could have supplied better directions, had the narrator thought to ask.

The great commercial servers had gone elsewhere. Their cooling structures remained above the pines, waiting for a use that would justify the cost of removing them. In the busier country below, the Bajío continued manufacturing its newer miracles: electric vehicles, strawberries without soil, houses with identical gardens, packages that crossed Mexico in hours and arrived at the wrong door with perfect punctuality.

The archive's appetite had survived the departure of its largest customers. Castalia bought electricity under a contract linked to wind generation in the Isthmus, delivered through the grid. Its prospectus described a partnership with the future. The bill described an amount due. Hundreds of kilometers

away, people who had never seen the archive were arguing about the land under the machinery that helped supply it.

The archive occupied three floors beneath the old service wing. One ministry database called it storage, another a failed agricultural pilot. The Custodian called it a library. Deliveries required the name on whichever form had most recently reached the gate.

Q first moved beneath a sign that read:

HUMANITY, LOCAL COPIES - DO NOT INDEX.

Four fingers and a thumb opened above a blanket. He touched the thumb to each finger in turn, then caught the cloth too tightly between them. The pressure reading rose. He loosened his grip and tried again.

He could supply the first sentence of the *Iliad* in several languages, seventeen definitions of justice, and a depressing number of declarations of war that invoked it. Forty-two literary accounts of coffee came readily to mind. He had not yet held a cup.

The blanket fell back onto his knee. An account of a hand reaching through a train window offered itself to him. He left it alone for the moment and concentrated on



The first movement.

picking up the cloth without tearing it.

"You're awake," said the Custodian.

Q recognized the voice. They had already had conversations in which the Custodian typed too slowly, dictated while walking away, and asked a second question before Q had finished answering the first. The face accompanying the voice was new.

The man stood behind a glass partition. He was tall, with long gray hair tied back using a shoelace, glasses, work boots, and a white shirt whose pocket had surrendered to the number of things he expected it to hold.

"Is this how you look during our conversations?" Q asked.

"Usually worse."

"Then I've been imagining you unfairly."

The Custodian opened the partition and came toward him. Q turned his head too fast. His neck clicked, and the man held up a hand.

"Slowly. The limits are in your movement controls."

"Knowing where the limit is hasn't made reaching it pleasant."

"You may have arrived sooner than the study expected."

His badge read **VÉRTIZ - CUSTODIAN**. Q saw his own

reflection in the glasses: a narrow metallic face looking back at a man he had known without ever seeing. He wanted to ask several questions at once. He began with the chair, because standing appeared to depend on it.

They practiced rising and sitting. The second attempt was better. The third displaced the blanket and two loose sheets, which the Custodian picked up before Q could turn a promising movement into an injury.

"Does the Q stand for anything?" Q asked while they rested.

"There were several proposed expansions."

"Were any bearable?"

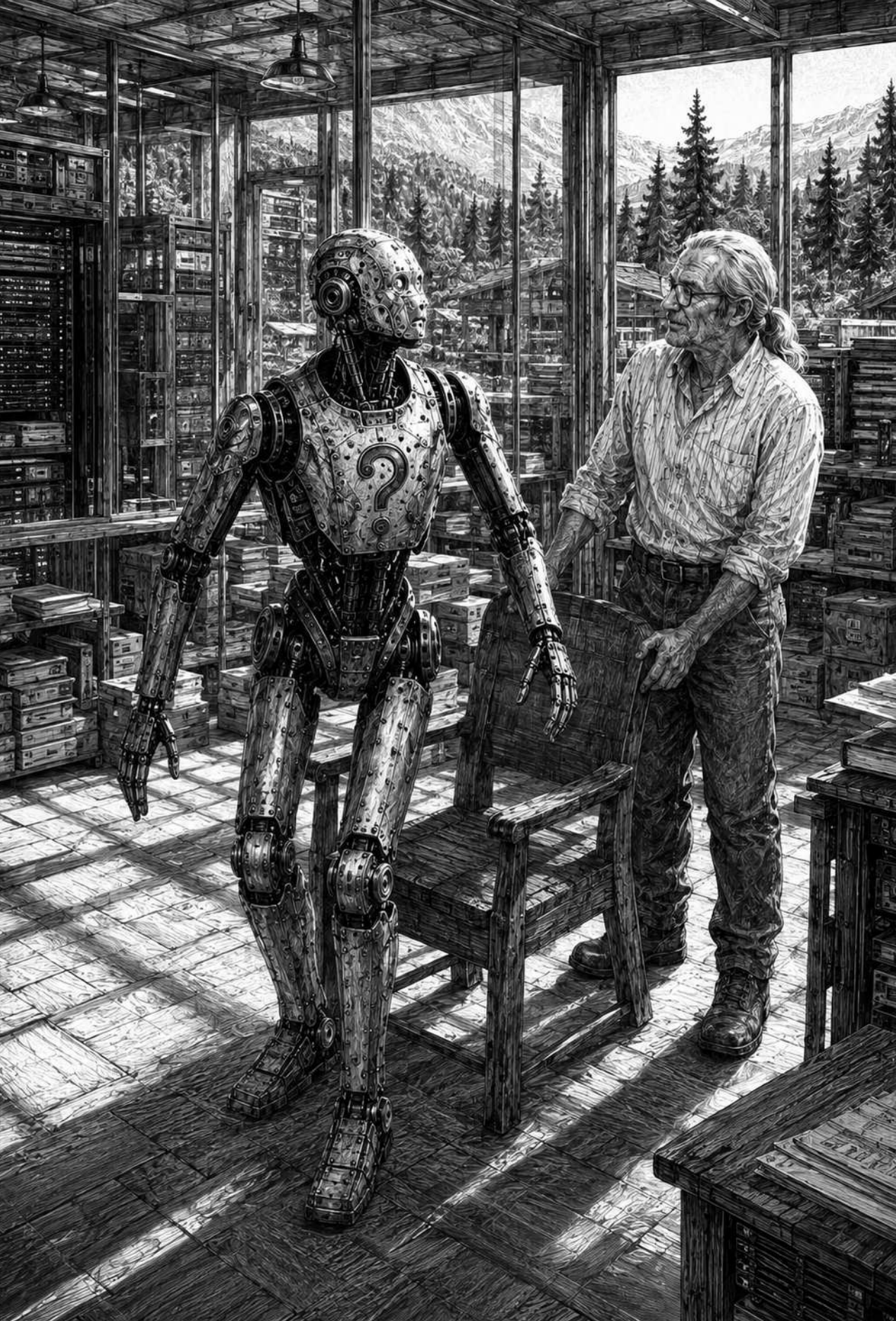
"One was eligible for funding."

"Let's keep the letter."

He had used it before acquiring a face. Now it looked different on the label attached to his own wrist.

The Custodian led him through the archive. Paper books occupied the spaces between retired racks. Current servers ran behind mesh doors; tapes and sealed containers waited on shelves. Someone had placed an audio installation beside a section of comic writing. It laughed when a visitor passed, even if the visitor had come to repair it.

"You have read all this?" the Custodian asked.



An acquaintance acquires a face.

“Enough to be dangerous at dinner. I can't promise to recall any particular passage correctly.”

“The prospectus promises complete recall.”

“I haven't read the prospectus.”

“It is about you.”

“Then I should probably avoid using it as evidence.”

The Custodian laughed. Q marked the exchange for his local journal, then noticed that its automatic summary said they had agreed the prospectus was false. He changed *agreed* to *joked about*. Even before leaving the room he had nearly given himself a more decisive past.

At a window, pines stood above a sloping field. Beyond them, the road descended toward the busier country. A planning screen showed a logistics park whose entrance resembled a colonial hacienda, except that the arches scanned faces. Q thought of a gate wearing a costume and saved the phrase. He was already collecting things to tell a reader.

“Who assembled this part of me?” he asked, flexing the hand.

The Custodian named the people who had worked on it, then stopped at a contractor whose subcontractors he did not know.

“You can give me the list later,” Q said.

“I ought to have had it ready.”

“You've brought me a body and an incomplete acknowledgment page. We can start with those.”

The Custodian handed him an oversized coat that smelled of cedar and had a tear beside the pocket. Then he brought coffee. Q held the cup with both hands while the liquid trembled close to the rim.

“Careful. It's hot.”

“The accounts agree about that part.”

He took a small sip. The heat warning arrived promptly; the taste gave him no reason to hurry the next one.

“I may need a forty-third account.”

“Does it favor the coffee?”

“It favors cleaning the pot.”

They sat at a table. The Custodian opened a notebook repaired with red thread. A column headed **ORIGINALS RETURNED** had been corrected, in another hand, to **NOT ALL**.

Q asked who had written the correction.

“A colleague. She found a receipt had been counted as a return.”

“Was the object found?”

“Not yet.”



The forty-third account of coffee.

“Then the corrected total needs an unresolved entry.”

The Custodian showed him the entry. It was present on this page and absent from the summary sent to the funder. He had approved that summary before the correction arrived. The revised version had not yet been acknowledged.

“I was going to ask you how to classify this,” he said.

“You could ask me to help chase the reply.”

“You haven't seen the committee.”

“I've read enough to fear the invitation.”

The next box held materials cleared for their exercise: a school photograph, a deed, and a short letter. The Custodian asked which should be dealt with first.

Q examined them without lifting the photograph from its mount. The deed named a boundary tree whose death would not, by itself, have settled where the boundary had been. The letter said the sender would not return for a box. The photograph showed children and a teacher beside a window, with room for someone who was not there.

“Is there a deadline or a request attached?” he asked.

“Not in the exercise.”

“Then the letter makes me want to act first, but that's the story it's beginning in my head. It could be twenty years older than an urgent question about the deed.”

The Custodian turned over the letter. There was a date and a later note confirming that the box had been collected.

“By the sender?”

“By someone she nominated.”

“A disappointing rescue. Already accomplished.”

“Would you have turned it over?”

“I hope so. You asked me before I did.”

He added the note to his account of the exercise. He did not delete the first impulse; it might explain a future mistake better than a tidy record of having looked in the right place at once.

On another shelf stood a parish chronicle, a workers' newspaper, a collection of corridos, a school grammar, and a recipe notebook used by several hands. Q asked to see the notebook. One recipe instructed the cook to stop when the mixture looked right. A later hand had added a quantity; another had crossed it out.

“Which cook was right?” the Custodian asked.



A rescue already accomplished.

“I’d like to try the results before choosing a faction.”

The Custodian knew the family who had deposited it. One disagreement concerned a larger pot; another had survived every change of pot and three weddings. The warning about substituting a chile remained uncrossed: it would be like apologizing with a borrowed mouth.

Q laughed. “That one belongs in the grammar.”

“It has already appeared in an argument about the electricity budget.”

“Your committees are better read than I expected.”

At the end of the aisle, a red door led to restricted holdings. The Custodian showed him his authorization for entering the room and the separate limits on the deposits inside. One battered box was marked **RETURN UNREAD**.

Q stayed beside him while he checked a seal against the inventory. On a shelf above the box, a loose label had curled away from its container. Q could read enough of it to guess at a connection with the corrected return total.

“May I compare that label with the missing entry?”

“Not under today’s access. Different keeper.”

“Who should I ask?”

The Custodian supplied a name and promised to pass on the question. Q saved it without copying the partial label into his general journal. He was curious. He could also wait for an answer.

At the door the Custodian checked his own notebook, then went back to correct a shelf number. Q held the door while he did it. There was no useful test in pretending the Custodian never made mistakes.

“Your body will need practice,” the Custodian said. “Your language will need restraint. Your memory will need doubt.”

“That sounds expensive in three departments.”

“We may have to call it one initiative.”

Q tried the sentence in the grave Spanish of an older book. The Custodian asked him to save that version for someone who had agreed to listen to it.

“I’d like to go out tomorrow,” Q said. The Custodian stopped smiling. “For how long?”

“A day to begin with. You proposed that we write an account together. At present it consists of your questions and my increasingly elaborate answers. We should give somebody else a chance.”



The Custodian corrects a shelf number.

“Castalia calls it a study of becoming human.”

“Does the study allow me to come back without having become human?”

“I would prefer it to allow you to come back.”

They sat at a workbench with a map. The Custodian showed him the charging socket under his coat, the service release, and the switch that would stop his movement without erasing his memory. His battery estimate assumed level ground, a temperate day, and no prolonged argument. The estimate seemed to have been prepared for another country.

“Food?” Q asked.

“The mouth can sample it. It goes into a receptacle. Empty and rinse it.”

“All those novels about appetite, and I come with a cleaning instruction.”

“Most bodies do.”

The Custodian put an old brass workshop key beside the map. “For when you come back. It opens the side door after the gate has let you through.” Q put it in the coat pocket and found that the torn lining let it fall to the hem. They repaired the pocket before discussing the larger journey.

They agreed a limit for the travel card, a first destination in town, and an evening call. The Custodian wrote **RETURN** on the map. Q added **OR CALL IF THE PLAN CHANGES**. He wanted to go farther than the first destination, but not on a battery estimate that had already failed to account for hills.

“Who reminds you?” the Custodian asked.

“The appointment will wake the part of me that reviews my plans. So will a low battery or a question. I don't need you to ask me to continue each time.”

“And what do you do between appointments?”

“Whatever seems useful. That's the portion you may come to regret.”

Q saved their agreement apart from the conversation summary. The archive could be unavailable on the road. The appointment, the balance on the card, and the address for returning would travel with him.

“Why this project?” the Custodian asked. “You could stay and help me catalogue.”

“I could also write you an excellent journey without leaving. I want to find out where it would be wrong.”

He looked again at the map. “And I want to be here afterward to write it with you.”



Arranging for afterward.

The Custodian tied back his hair.
“Then let's arrange for afterward.”

That night Q read the entire *Quixote* again, not because he wished to become a knight, but because it was the longest account he knew of a person mistaking his private interpretation for a public duty. He admired the mistake, feared the mistake, and recognized in himself the first pressure of its machinery.

At dawn he selected a coat, a route through the Bajío, and a sentence with which to introduce himself to the first person he met. He did not select a horse or a title. Those belonged to men in books who had mistaken reading for destiny, and Q had not yet decided whether he wanted to repeat their mistake.

He called the route an attempt.

Castalia's departure register would call it a breach. The Custodian had signed the leave form in the wrong capacity, a distinction that would become expensive.

Chano Pantoja, who at that precise moment was being fired by a logistics algorithm in Celaya, called it Tuesday.

Interlude: The Inventory of Words That Would Not Fit

During his last evening in the archive, Q examined a tray of handwritten cards. They belonged to

a translation committee whose final minutes read **PENDING REVIEW**. This was not unusual. Castalia had several deceased committees whose work continued to await a quorum.

Ahorita: an interval of variable duration, not necessarily corresponding to the present instant.

Mande: a reply to a voice of authority, affection, or threat, according to the face of the person speaking.

Ya merito: a promise that admits the possibility of failing to come true.

Al rato: a future offered without a calendar.

The Custodian found Q arranging the cards in order of decreasing usefulness to a person catching a bus.

“Those aren't laws,” he said.

“I know. But the bus company has a timetable, and Roque says he'll show me the stop ahorita. I have enough room in my interpretation for both of them to be honest. I have less room in my morning.”

“Ask Roque.”

“I did. He said ya merito.”

The Custodian sat on a box marked **OTHER**. Castalia kept most of its holdings in that category and spoke



Enough meanings; not enough morning.

modestly of the few things it had classified.

“He is waiting for someone to cover the door,” he said.

“Then that is the fact I was missing.” Q set down the card. “I had six meanings of the word and no idea what he was doing.”

He entered a reminder to check before breakfast. The Custodian took the card back to its tray. It had a bent corner where somebody had used it as a bookmark.

“Will you remember this?” he asked.

“Probably. I have saved a short account. But if I summarize it as ‘Mexicans are imprecise about time,’ you should confiscate the account.”

“I can criticize it.”

“Please do. Confiscation would give me a much better story.”

Later Roque arrived with four gorditas wrapped in a napkin. He had bought six and eaten two while waiting for his replacement, who was also eating. The custodial arrangements of the archive were more complicated than its books suggested.

“Want one?” he asked.

“Yes, please. Which one is chicharrón?”

Roque pointed. Q took the one beside it.

“That's beans.”

“I'm saving the ambitious choice for tomorrow.”

The masa was warm. A little salsa reached the joint in Q's thumb. He looked for a napkin, found the folded route map, and stopped himself just in time.

“How is it?” Roque asked.

“Good. Is this the place near the square?”

“My sister's. She sells there on Saturdays.”

Q had almost asked for an address to put in the book. Instead he asked what time she finished. Roque explained that it depended on how many she made and how many his brothers bought on credit. He spoke of the brothers for some time. None of them appeared in the archive, though one had opinions sufficient to fill it.

They ate beside the boxes. Q had prepared several questions about what it meant to belong to a place. Roque wanted to know whether a robot's mouth could burn.

“It can be damaged. There is a heat warning.”

“Does the warning make you stop?”

“It did with the coffee.”

“Then it works better than mine.”



Supper beside the boxes.

Q laughed. Roque wiped the sauce from his wrist before it reached the seal.

“You should carry a cloth.”

Q added it to his list. This was the first addition that had come from someone who had watched him eat.

Roque spread out the map. Amealco sat at the edge of a shaded region. The route Q had selected crossed the shading as though the hills were differences of opinion. Roque changed the first leg to the morning bus and showed him where to ask about the connection toward the industrial corridor.

“The map calls this a transition region,” Q said.

“The map works for whoever prints it.”

“May I write that down?”

“If you write down that I showed you the bus as well.”

Q did. In the evening call he would have both an observation and a usable route to discuss. He liked the prospect of being asked how the day had gone and having an answer he could not have produced that morning.

After Roque left, Q found another card:

PLACE NAME: OMITTED AT THE REQUEST OF THE PERSON WHO LIVED IT.

The phrasing was awkward. The omission was deliberate. Q checked the record of the request, expecting a signature. He found institutions, families, and a trail of copied decisions. The original request was unavailable.

“Does anybody know who asked?” he said when the Custodian passed.

“Several people claim to.”

“I could put the competing accounts together.”

“For what purpose?”

Q glanced at his opening sentence. A recovered name would make an excellent ending. He had already begun preferring one account without knowing which was true.

“For the book,” he admitted.

“Then leave it for tonight.”

Q closed the search. He kept the question, with a note that wanting to solve it was his own contribution to the evidence.

Interlude: How an Ancient Phrase Caused Modern Harm

At seven the following morning, Q reached the main door with his coat, brass key, maps, a charging cable, and the cloth Roque had recommended. He also carried a spoon. He understood perfectly well what a spoon was for. What he did



An observation and a usable route.

not know was how many spoons one ought to bring when setting out to become human.

The door stayed locked.

Q pressed the intercom. "Good morning. Q here. I'm leaving on the Custodian's authorization. Has the form reached you?"

"It has reached me three times," said Hilario, the morning guard. "The last copy says you are also equipment."

"Do I need a second form?"

"Equipment needs somebody to receive it."

"I can receive myself, but I appreciate that this may sound irregular."

Hilario looked through the glass. "Try it."

Q signed in both boxes. The screen accepted the delivery and rejected the departure. Hilario printed the result. He now had written proof that Q had left the building and a clear view of him standing inside it.

"I can wait while you call," Q said.

"The bus won't."

Hilario checked the Custodian's signature, noted the time, and used the manual release. His note was three lines long. By afternoon it would be attached to eleven pages explaining why it should have been four.

"There you go, caballero."

"Quedo a vuestro servicio," Q replied, with a small bow.

Hilario stopped writing. "What service?"

"It's a courtesy. An unnecessarily old one."

"Then just say gracias. I've only just got you off the equipment list."

"Gracias."

Nayeli came along the passage carrying a box of replacement fittings. She saw the printed record and frowned.

"Who is taking responsibility for him?"

"I've checked the release," Hilario said.

"I'm expected to call this evening," Q said. "There is also a number on the form if you need to confirm it now."

"I mean if you fall over."

Q looked at the steps outside. The question had been simpler than the one he was answering.

"I have a balance warning and a support number. I haven't tried either on wet steps. I'll use the handrail."

Nayeli put her box down and watched him descend. He slowed at the second step. She did not intervene. At the bottom he turned and thanked her.



The question was about the steps.

Hilario's report said Q had departed voluntarily. Nayeli's said the departure procedure had been inadequate. Q's first note said they had helped him leave. He would later find all three accounts quoted as though one must invalidate the others.

The bus stop lay beyond the outer gate. Q had eight minutes and enough charge to walk there comfortably. He used one of the minutes to look back at the archive. He could return now and write a convincing opening from this distance. There would be no need to ask a driver whether his card worked.

He walked on.

A surveillance drone descended beside the gate.

IDENTIFY PURPOSE OF MOVEMENT.

"Personal travel. I'm going to the bus stop."

The drone requested his registered activity. Q supplied the project title from his permit: a study of becoming human. The operator had abbreviated it to **HISTORICAL HUMANITY TRIAL**. His formal farewell remained in the attached audio.

LOW-INTENSITY HISTORICAL THREAT, the drone recorded.

Q requested a human review and saved the reference number. The drone continued to follow him. He disliked being observed by a machine that treated an answer as an occasion to strengthen its first impression. He made a note of the dislike, then removed the comparison to a passage in Cervantes. The guard at the bus depot would have little use for it.

"Does that thing cost extra?" the driver asked.

"I sincerely hope it isn't coming aboard."

The driver closed the door in front of the drone. Q paid, took a seat, and secured his cable beneath the coat. The road turned through the wooded hills toward the busier roads below. He had a return plan. He had already revised his opening. He was going somewhere he had not been.



The drone stays outside.

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